

The Data & Decisions Cheat Sheet

Every concept, term and trap from Lessons 5.1 to 5.5, each with the lever it gives you.

THE DECISION LOOP5.1

Question	What am I actually trying to decide? Skip this and the rest is decoration.
Pull AI owns this	Get the numbers out. Collapsed . You ask in plain English instead of writing sequel.
Read AI owns this	Turn numbers into a claim. Sped up, and it will propose a cause . That cause is a hypothesis.
Decide yours	Choose. Untouched by AI, and untouchable.
Act yours	Ship it, cut it, or re-scope it. Two arcs of five changed. The other three are you.

THE ONLY THREE DECISIONS5.1

Prioritization	Ten things, one quarter. What do we build next?
Validation	Shipped six weeks ago. Did the metric it was meant to move, move?
Diagnosis	Activations down 9%, exec channel noticed first. Why did the number move?

Serves none of the three? It is not analysis. It is **decoration**.

ASK IT WELL · THREE SHAPES5.2

Show me the outcome	Retention, conversion, weekly actives. Name the result, let it find the metric.
What is causing this	Point at a drop, ask it across releases, segments, seasonality.
What performs best	Rank the plans, channels, onboarding variants.
Always add two	A window and a segment . "How is retention?" is a mood. "Retention for self-serve teams, two weeks after launch vs the two before" has a shape.
Never dictate	Brief the outcome , never the chart type .

CHECK THE QUERY, NOT THE CHART5.2

The analogue of "click the citation". These tools all show their work. **Open the panel**.

1. Definition	What exactly did it count? "Active" as any login or as created a booking is the same word and a different company.
2. Window	Up 40% against what? A number with no baseline is a vanity number.
3. Sample	How many users? 40% of 30 people is noise wearing a percentage sign.
4. Privacy	Inside Amplitude or Mixpanel you are in governed data. Copy rows into a public chatbot and you aggregate and strip identifiers first .

The moment it is on your slide it is **yours**. Nobody asks the tool what it meant by "active". They ask you.

THE WORDS, AND WHAT THEY COST YOU5.1-5.4

Vanity metric	Goes up, changes nothing. Test: if it doubled tomorrow, would I know what to change?
Confounder	A third thing causing both. Power users adopt the feature <i>and</i> retain.
Survivorship bias	Studying who stayed to learn why people leave. The answer is standing in the gap.
HIPPO	Highest paid person's opinion. The old failure mode, from when there was no data.
False precision	A decimal place laid on top of guesses. The new one, and it looks rigorous.

THE NUMBERS, AND WHERE THEY CAME FROM

2016	RICE was published by Intercom's product team, for their own roadmap. Sean McBride, Intercom, 2016
12.4k 3.1k	The same "active users" question, counted as any login versus created a booking. Lesson 5.2, on the scheduling tool
Jun 2026	Mixpanel's assistant stopped being Spark and became Mixpanel Agent. PERISHABLE, the name on the button changed inside a year. Check the monthly update.

RICE, PRECISELY5.3

Reach × Impact × Confidence ÷ Effort

Reach owned by data	People or events affected per period. A count. Checkable, so check it .
Impact owned by you	Per person, fixed scale: 3 massive · 2 high · 1 medium · 0.5 low · 0.25 minimal.
Confidence owned by you	A percentage. 100 solid data · 80 good evidence · 50 a hunch.
Effort owned by eng	Person-months. Ask them. Do not guess it .

Three of the four are estimates. AI may **draft** all four. It may never **own** Confidence.

THE FALSE-PRECISION TRAP5.3

14.7 beats 12.3, so A won on merit. Change one Confidence from 80% to 50%, a number you invented, and **the ranking flips**. Nothing about the world changed.

A precise score built on soft inputs is a guess wearing a lab coat. The decimal point is not evidence.

Anchor, then argue	Fill Reach and Effort from real sources first. Then debate Impact and Confidence as a team, out loud.
Evidence sentence	One line beside every Confidence . "80%, because two other teams shipped this and saw the lift." No sentence = a wish.

what did I leave off?

argue against my top item

"the spreadsheet decided"

METRICS RED FLAGS · THE SIX TRAPS5.4

- Correlation is not cause**
"Calendar-sync users retain 2×. Push everyone onto sync."
What else is true about the people who do this? Power users do both.
- Vanity, not actionable**
Signups, pageviews, "engagement up 20%".
If this doubled tomorrow, would I know what to change?
- The sample is too small**
"Conversion up 40% this week!" On 30 users.
How many users, and could this just be random?
- Who is missing**
Survivorship: studying active users to learn why people churn.
Who is NOT in this data?
- The average hides it · Simpson's paradox**
Headline up, every team's dashboard down, because the mix shifted. Both are true.
Break it down by segment before believing any headline.
- Bias baked into the data**
"Double down on this segment", because it is what you measured most.
Whose behaviour generated this, and who is underrepresented?

THE ONE REFLEX5.4

Make the AI argue against its own conclusion. Paste this after any cause it hands you:

"What would have to be true for this to be wrong? Give me the most boring explanation: seasonality, a bug, a mix shift, a small sample."

A cause that **survives** is worth acting on. One that **collapses** was a story.

Does this move a decision?

Can I defend, out loud, how it was measured?

Two noes and it does not go on the slide.

THE ARTIFACT5.5

One page, six sections. Every number traces back to a query somebody else can run.

the decision

the metric + its query

ranked backlog + evidence

recommendation

risks, written by you

how we will know

Not your opinion. A decision with its working shown.